

EYEWITNESS July 18, 1863

Assault on Fort Wagner

Strategically located on South Carolina's Morris Island, Fort Wagner played a crucial role in the protection of Charleston. In July 1863, Union troops unsuccessfully engaged in two battles while attempting to capture the fort. One of the first Black American units, Colonel Robert Gould Shaw's 54th Massachusetts Volunteer Infantry, spearheaded the attack on July 18.

"The 54th, the past week, has proved itself twice in battle ... on Saturday afternoon we were marched up past our batteries, amid the cheers of the officers and soldiers. We wondered what they were all cheering for, but we soon found out. Gen. Strong rode up, and we halted. Well, you had better believe there was some guessing what we were to do. Gen. Strong asked us if we would follow him into Fort Wagner. Every man said, yes—we were ready to follow wherever we were led. You may all know Fort Wagner is the Sebastopol of the rebels; but we went at it, over the ditch and on to the parapet through deadly fire; but we could not get into the fort. We met the foe on the parapet of Wagner with the bayonet—we were exposed to a murderous fire from the batteries of the fort, from our Monitors and our land batteries, as they did not cease firing soon enough. Mortal men could not stand such a fire, and the assault on Wagner was a failure ... at the first charge the 54th rushed to within twenty yards of the ditches ... the color bearer of the State colors was killed on the parapet. Col. Shaw seized the staff when the standard bearer fell, and in less than a minute after, the Colonel fell himself. When the men saw their gallant leader fall, they made a desperate effort to get him out, but they were either shot down, or reeled in the ditch below ... I have no more paper here at present ... so I cannot further particularize in this letter."

CORPORAL JAMES HENRY GOODING, 54TH MASSACHUSETTS VOLUNTEER INFANTRY, IN A LETTER OF JULY 20, 1863